

W.E.B. Du Bois's position in the sociological canon

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Abstract

Over the past two decades there have been repeated calls to recognize W.E.B Du Bois as a member of the sociological canon (e.g. Morris 2015, Zuckerman 2004). Here I show how recognition of the importance of Du Bois' work has grown since the 1990s by comparison with three generations of theorists. Compared to the classic trio (Weber, Durkheim, and Marx), only Weber is still significantly more cited than Du Bois'. His standing is similar when compared to the generation who developed the sociological canon (e.g. Merton and Parsons). It is only among the last cohort of general sociological theorists (Bourdieu, Giddens, and Habermas) that we can find a trajectory of recognition capable of overshadowing Du Bois', and that is Bourdieu's. I also show how despite the increasing recognition of Du Bois he remains an isolated figure, who, unlike Bourdieu, appears to be often cited in isolation from authors in the sociological canon.

"American sociology is belatedly starting to acknowledge that Du Bois was one of the founders of the discipline" (Itzigsohn & Brown, 2021)

Claims about the popularity or lack thereof of a theorist are part of the discourse in handbooks, courses, and chatter between sociologists. For instance, Parsons famously began *The Structure of Social Action* rhetorically asking "who now reads Spencer?" (Parsons, 1937). Decades later, others wondered "who now reads Parsons?" Bryant, 1983. Yet, that was only a few years before Jeffrey Alexander would claim that "with the exception of Habermas, no post-classical sociological theorist is more talked about today in Europe and the United States

than Parsons himself” Alexander, 1988. Disagreements are understandable, as these claims are contingent on the authors’ position. They are also strategic, a segue into a more important point the author wants to make about changes in the field. Because acquiring a sense of the who’s who of sociological theory is still an important aspect of the socialization of new sociologists I offer here a new perspective. for that purpose, I use citation counts for some classical and modern sociological theorists starting with the foundation of the American Journal of Sociology in 1985 to the present date.

Without any pretension to define boundaries in the canon of sociological theory, I take a set of authors that frequently appear in classical and modern sociological theory courses. Karl Marx, Emile Durkheim, Max Weber, and W.E.B Du Bois as classical theorists. Robert K. Merton and Talcott Parsons are included as representatives of the generation that helped establish a canon in sociological theory Joas and Knöbl, 2009. Lastly, I include Pierre Bourdieu, Anthony Giddens, and Jürgen Habermas as members of the last generation of sociological theorists who developed general theoretical systems. The data contains all articles (including book reviews) published in the American Journal of Sociology, American Sociological Review, Sociological Theory, and Social Forces. Because these journals were founded in different years¹ the composition changes over time. I present total and not relative counts so the trends can be read as representing both the change in popularity of these authors as well as the growth of the discipline over the twentieth century. All the code and data (collected from Google Scholar) are available in a public repository (link not included for anonymity).

The popularity of the classic trio (Weber, Durkheim, Marx) grew in parallel to that of those who helped establish them as central figures in sociology. Nevertheless, the number of citations of these classic authors went down slower than that of Merton and Parsons. Of the three, Weber is now the most cited. Du Bois, who was four years younger than Weber, only became widely cited after the turn of the millennium, and he is now almost as often cited as Durkheim. In the case of Bourdieu, Giddens, and Habermas we can see how these three authors, who position themselves as general theorists in the ’80s, had remarkably similar trends at the time, but whilst Bourdieu’s popularity kept growing

¹The American Journal of Sociology was founded in 1895, Social Forces in 1922, American Sociological Review in 1936, and Sociological Theory in 1983.

and eventually surpassed Parsons in the '90s, Habermas and Giddens slowly lost their share.

Bourdieu not only became highly cited but also took over Parsons' central role in the co-citation network of theorists (figure insets). Parsons was the most central node in the '50s, '60s, and '70s, a role that was taken over by Weber who has been the most central node ever since. By the '2010s Bourdieu had displaced Parsons as the contemporary author at the core of the network, standing next to Weber ².

²Being a weighted network, the position of the nodes depends on the strength of their ties to other nodes (which is the number of articles in which two authors are cited together). Thus, the position of a node is dependent on the author's popularity, although it does not result directly from it. For instance, although Du Bois was frequently cited during the '2010s he was the least central node in the network.

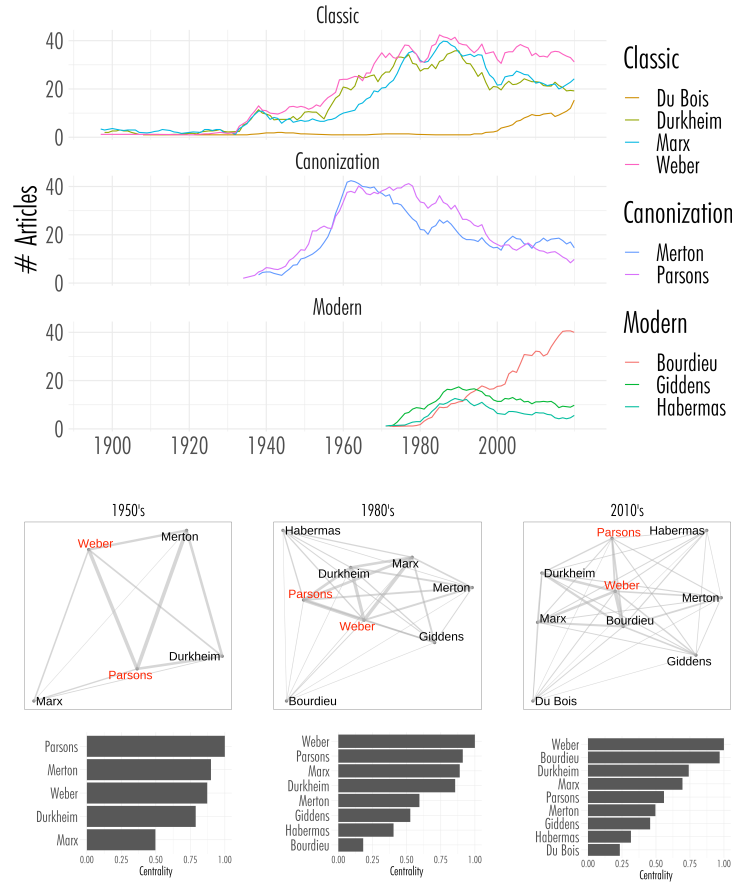


Figure 1: **Number of citations of sociological theorists over time.** Includes all articles published in the American Journal of Sociology, American Sociological Review, Sociological Theory, and Social Forces since their foundation. The y-axis represents the moving average of the number of articles citing an author published in a given year. Sliding window of 4 years. **Bottom insets represent co-citation networks of selected decades and eigenvector centrality measures.** The width of the tie between two nodes corresponds to the number of articles citing both authors. Authors with less than 10 citations in a decade are excluded.

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